

Matthew 4; Luke 4–5

The Spirit of the Lord Is upon Me

- He just got baptised -
- He's about to go north into the Galilee again and begin his ministry officially.
- Matthew 4:1 - compare with Luke 4:1
- He goes out into that Judean wilderness for 40 days.
 - Just as Jesus did, we all need to take designated time away from things to connect with God.
 - Luke 5:16
 - When was the last time you withdrew yourself and went into the "Wilderness" so to speak and prayed.

1b. To be with God - and then afterwards he was tempted by the Devil.

- If all you had was the King James version of the Bible, you could actually draw the conclusion that before Jesus begins his ministry he needed to confront that direct temptation, the direct opposition that's going to be a constant influence in not only his life, but in the lives of his disciples, and in the lives of people for the rest of time.
- You could make the argument that - ya, he needed to have that experience to overcome the devil.
- JST says, before he begins his ministry, he's going to take some time to get away and connect with God and to commune with the Lord and receive his direction from God.

Matthew 4:2

- Afterward an hungered.
- The principle that might be communicated out of those words is:
- Jesus wasn't focused on his hunger. He wasn't focused on his fast.
- He was fasting so that he could focus on God and after he had spent that time communing and connecting with God, then as he's coming out of the wilderness, now he recognizes more fully, I'm hungry. I'm ready to eat.
- There's a principle there for us to apply ourselves next time you come to an opportunity to fast. When you feel those hunger pains, instead of focusing on those and thinking:
 - Oh how miserable this is!
- Instead having those be a reminder to turn heavenward and try to connect more fully with God. Trying to fulfill the purposes for which you're fasting on that particular occasion.

Howard W. Hunter

Such a time is always the tempter's moment—when we are emotionally or physically spent, when we are weary, vulnerable, and least prepared to resist the insidious suggestions he makes. This was an hour of danger—the kind of moment in which many men fall and succumb to the subtle allurements of the devil.

- Satan often attacks us when we are hungry and potentially discombobulated.
 - Have you ever found yourself to be hangry?
 - When we're hungry we're in a weakened state, and Satan will just capitalize on anything.
 - And the natural man is like Rawr!
-
- Satan will often attack us following a profound spiritual outpouring.
 - Don't skip over this, because if you're preparing to go to the temple... and the next thing is like this sucker punch right
 - When we remind ourselves that it's going to come, it's so helpful because instead of thinking
 - What have I done wrong? Hey, I've been doing everything right.
 - When you realize that it's part of the flow of life's trajectory it's a little easier to manage and get through.

Matthew 4:3 (Deut 8:3)

- So here's Jesus; Satan comes tempting him.
- Notice the significance of these words because this is the first recorded statement from the devil in the New Testament.
- Notice the very first word that Satan uses:
 - He came to Jesus and he said, ***If*** thou be the Son of God...
- Satan uses this temptation technique of planting a seed of doubt onto the soul.
- If you're really the Son of God... basically it's this ***prove it***, turn these stones, "command that these stones be made bread."
- Now... I don't think there would be anything wrong with Jesus breaking his fast at this particular point.
 - He's spent forty days and forty nights, the purpose is fulfilled, it would be fine for him to break his fast. That doesn't seem to be the real temptation.
- From my perspective here it's:
 - Jesus, use your God given power to gratify your own appetites, your own desires, to use them selfishly.
 - Prove that you're the Son of God by commanding that these stones be turned into bread.

Matthew 4:5 (Deut 8:3)

- Once again, we thank thee O God for a prophet.
- JST The devil is not going to take Jesus anywhere he does not want to go.
 - And wouldn't you find it odd that, if the devil did take Jesus to somewhere, that he would choose to take him to the temple?
- JST "Then Jesus was taken up into the holy city, and the Spirit setteth him on the pinnacle of the temple."
- And what does the devil say? "***If***"
 - For the second time, planting seeds of doubt again.
- Another lesson of life:
 - Satan is very patient, he's very persistent.
 - He'll try and try and try again. And just because I overcome a temptation, a particular weakness, that he's trying to get me to fall today, doesn't mean I can celebrate and say:
 - Whew, I overcame that battle, victory won!
 - Because life's lessons have proven that time and time and time again he's going to come back and try again with some of these same techniques as he does here.

Matthew 4:5 (Deut 8:3)

- Let's think about in today's age in our YouTube/TikToc world where people do all sorts of outrageous things to have a virally sensational presence on the world stage.
- Jesus could have gotten immediate fame, not just in Jerusalem, but throughout the Roman Empire, everybody would have known the story of the man who jumped from the pinnacle and angels had stopped him.
- There would have been thousands and thousands of people right there in Jerusalem that all would have seen it.
- So here's Jesus, who needs to get the message out about who he is.
- This would have been a very, very fast way of doing it
- - versus taking the slow path of hanging out in the Galilee and walking from small village to small village on dusty roads talking to the poor and the lonely.
- But that's what he chose to do, and I love that he did not take the path to quick fame and fortune.
- He knew his real identity and that he could do God's work without having to sensationalize who he was or his message.

Matthew 4:6 (Psalm 91:11-12), 7

- It is written...
- You've got to be kidding me, the devil is quoting scripture to Jesus in an attitude of tempting him,
 - which tells you that the devil knows the scriptures and he can apply them in nefarious ways for his own devious and deceptive purposes.
- v7 - thou shalt not tempt the Lord thy God.
 - I used to think he was saying this to the devil: thou shalt not tempt me.
- Instead, I think he's saying to the devil,
 - don't do things to put God in a position where you're tempting him.
 - If I throw myself off I'm now tempting...
 - You have to send your angels to save me,
 - And he's saying I'm not going to do that to Heavenly Father.
 - I'm not going to make those kinds of demands of him.
 - I'm going to do his will; I'm not going to make him do my will.

Matthew 4:9 (Deut 8:3)

- So these first two temptations deal with this question of, you know - if.
- Is your identity really the Son of God?
- So there's both the tempting and casting of doubt.
- Then the devil changes his tactics in the very next temptation.
- Did you pick up on the pattern here?
 - Three temptations and three times Jesus uses the words "It is written"
- He knows the scripts and he's using them to draw strength to overcome the devil.
- There's a principle there for us to apply in our lives today.
- To perhaps memorize a couple of key scriptures, and maybe some key hymns or lyrics that are powerful and sacred to you so that in moments of weakness, moments of clear temptation, you might be able to discern what's going on and respond not with a,
 - Oh should I do this or should I not?
 - But rather, wait a minute, I recognize what's happening here, it is written, and then quote your favorite scripture or sing a hymn.

Merrill J. Bateman

There are certain blessings obtained from searching the scriptures, Elder Bateman related. "As a person studies the words of the Lord and obeys them, he or she draws closer to the Savior and obtains a greater desire to live a righteous life. The power to resist temptation increases and spiritual weaknesses are overcome. Spiritual wounds are healed."

Bread, Disciples, Kingdoms -> Appetites, Fame and Vanity, Power and Riches

- So if you look at all of the temptations, there's a common thread going on here.
- What Satan is proposing is for Jesus to do something - to break eternal covenants with Heavenly Father, and to use his power or to invoke God's power to save him
- in order to get *instantaneous gratification*.
- Instant bread, I don't want to have to go home and grind some grain and make some dough and form it into loaves and start a fire and have to bake some bread.
 - I want what I want and I want it now
 - This is a very devilish approach to life.
- That's what we saw up in the premortal council. He didn't want to suffer, he didn't want to have to work for salvation, he wanted all of the glory without it costing him anything.
 - Short change the process
 - You don't have to go walk those dusty streets of Galilee
- Every temptation that knocks on your door is an invitation to become more like the devil.
- It is to get something that you either haven't earned or don't deserve or it's not rightfully yours and to take it out of time or out of order or out of place or in the wrong context,
- it is not according to God's law.

- This is an interesting pattern that we see expressed here in the New Testament
- What happens if we try to bypass the work and the effort that's involved in working for ourselves?
 - To be able to earn our daily bread,
 - working to build relationships
 - putting in the time and effort to build the kingdom of God
- Sometimes it's not as simple as we all wish it would be.
- God is inviting us in these efforts
 - to learn to repent around things that we have done that might hurt other people
 - and to forgive when people do things that might bother us
 - But ultimately to be reminded of the joy and value in labor and work.
- Consider in your own life: when have you found joy?
 - Have you found joy by things just automatically appearing without any effort?
 - Or working hard over time and seeing growth and progress?
- This is an invitation that we work diligently with the Lord for our own salvation and in that process we experience joy because of the efforts we've put into it.

- That something's that super tempting to me and that I've struggled with, becomes less tempting and less of a struggle when I learn the lessons that I feel like I'm intended to learn from it or that I need to learn from it.
- And so I don't say: hey, take this away God.
- Instead I'm like: why am I struggling with this?
 - Can you teach me?
 - Teach me what I need to know so that this experience isn't wasted. So the struggle isn't wasted.
 - I want to maximize the benefit and purpose of that.
 - So instead of getting down on myself and thinking: oh, you're such a spiritual lower
 - I'll be like: can you teach me? Why do I keep struggling with this kind of stuff.
 - And that's where the true transformation begins.

“Just as [a] magnet is unable to exercise power over a faraway metal object, as we resist temptation, it fades away and loses its power over our mind and heart and, consequently, over our actions,”

(Elder Ulisses Soares, “Seek Christ in Every Thought,” Ensign, Nov. 2020).

- Becoming like God is a process of learning.
- Be patient with ourselves
- and instead of getting down on ourselves next time we fall and do something we regret.
- Fall to our knees and say: I’m sorry. What can I and should I be learning from this?
- And our weaknesses suddenly start to become a strength.